

# ***Tzelem Elohim in the Other***

## **Social Encounter as Nearness to God**

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Unlike other living creatures, human life carries an additional task beyond the challenge of bodily survival: the task of finding sense and meaning in the very wish to go on living. From the moment reflective consciousness descended into the world and began to dwell in the brain of the crown of creation, a gap opened up between the raw life-drive in the soul and the powers of action and doing. A human being cannot simply “walk in accordance with his nature.” Instead, he is time and again placed before his rational awareness – that faculty which mediates between his senses and the movements of his limbs, and which, in the space between them, weaves a symbolic, conceptual, spiritual layer, thickening as the cortex itself thickens.

The ability to pause and to wonder between impulse and deed, to inquire into the nature of things; the ability to name them, to arrange them into patterns preserved in memory, to liken one thing to another and ultimately to build a rich and complex system of concepts and ideas – this is what impels, even compels, the human being not to leave the bare fact of his being alive as a mere fact, a simple “this is how it is,” but to seek, energetically, a perspective that will grant this fact a positive context, a story – something that will transform “this is” into “this is good,” into “this is worthy.”

This essay will touch on the question of the meaning of life – which, as Camus famously wrote, is the only question truly worthy of concern. But my aim here is not to offer you, the reader, *the* meaning of your life, nor even to sharpen the particular meaning that you have likely already found for it. Instead, I will look at two overarching answers to the question of meaning – or, more precisely, two basic *fields* of experienced meaning.

One field lies along a **horizontal axis**, where a person turns to his sociocultural environment, to the human other. The second lies along a **vertical axis** and directs a person’s gaze toward God. The main discussion will revolve around the relationship between these two meaning-axes: the tension that can arise between them, and the life-paths and cultural trajectories that are paved when one axis is given preference over the other.

At the heart of the essay, I will propose a key for relating these two fields of meaning – a key whose task is to bridge, and to some extent even fuse, them; to draw on the power of each field and compose from them a sense of meaning that is deep and exhilarating. In brief, this key lies in the insight that human beings – and in particular the human beings who constitute my world, my human others – are powerful and unique manifestations of God, **tzelem Elohim**, such that from the image in their faces the face of the Creator of the world gazes back at me.

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## **A. The Other**

The most natural and common way to escape the meaninglessness of life is to lean on the human other. To unpack this claim, let us look at several circles of life that constitute vital systems of existential meaning.

### **Morality**

As suggested above, our consciousness needs some kind of “purpose” in order to sustain willing in a way that is clear to ourselves. We are used to managing our steps deliberately and with planning. We tend, therefore, to picture ourselves as “moving toward” something we want to achieve, rather than as merely being driven by a faceless inner push.

When we are hungry and cook ourselves a good meal, we hold in mind an image of the upcoming, satisfying, enjoyable eating; that image more than anything else defines and clarifies for us the motivation to cook – much more than a mental picture of our rumbling stomach. This illustrates the thickening of the symbolic-mental layer that mediates – and simultaneously distances – sensation from action.

This phenomenon holds at different levels of resolution in our willing. The desire to cook dinner is concrete, local and time-bound; the desire to take driving lessons, to study for a degree, or to maintain a long-term relationship expresses a higher-order will that is present in consciousness over days, weeks and years, shaping the macro-levels of life. At the far end of the scale, a mature person finds a general “framing story” within which he situates his life. In order to live with joy and satisfaction – and even simply in order to plan his future in a thoughtful, rational, consistent way – a person must define, to some degree of clarity, his most basic life-goals. He cannot be left only with impulses and instincts.

In other words: the central variable at the heart of human life is the **value question**. The question of basic goals is equivalent to the question of a person’s values – what he experiences as good, what he thinks is worth striving for.

In the higher strata of our personality – the strata responsible for the “higher-order desires” that accompany us for years – we often try to place **moral values** at the center of life. A moral value is a goal whose source is a moral motive – a motive that can be identified, by way of contrast, as one that is not oriented toward selfish pleasure, but outward, toward someone or something else.

Most people who wish to see themselves as “good,” as possessing moral values, assign a special place to the moral will in their worldview. On that basis, at the macro level of life, a grand “framing story” becomes possible – a story that can lend power and beauty to our natural desire to live: *we want to live in order to make the world a better place.*

It is important to stress that this is not a form of self-deception, nor a naïve belief that the moral will is stronger or more natural than the animal survival instinct within us. But one cannot live “off instincts” alone. We are forced to tell ourselves a story that will help us lead ourselves through the endless forest of decisions that is life. Among all those possible stories, the moral story – living in order to do good in the world – shines with a special light.

It is easy to see how the moral system rests entirely on the human other. When we say that we want to make the world a better place, what could we mean if not making it a better place **for the people who live in it?**

In general, the moral system – at least the one held by us in contemporary Western society – concerns almost exclusively the fair regulation of the social space, and the interactions that are fitting or unfitting to conduct with other human beings. For some, the main moral values revolve around human rights, liberty and equality for all citizens of the state, and ideally for all people. Others place compassion, kindness, friendship and love in the core of their moral vocabulary; others include responsibility for the environment, out of concern for future generations of humankind.

There are many ways to formulate and organize our moral values. Yet from any angle, the basic element that makes something “good” is that it is **“good for someone.”** When we are filled with the wish to do good, its practical translation will usually be some improvement in the situation or experience of certain human beings who are our others.

## **Family**

In practice, the values that guide us through life are not only general moral values, which are abstract to a significant extent, but also more specific and concrete values. In most cultures – including our own – the value that frames perhaps the largest portion of a person’s daily hours is tied to the **family framework** in which he lives.

Within the “mainstream” cultural template of “respectable life,” of life that are proper and “normal,” couplehood, parenthood and family occupy a central place. This centrality is not always reflected in our explicit value discourse – the one that takes place in the media, in philosophical writing or in academic discussion – but it is decisive at the level of life themselves.

A huge portion of the worries and energies of the average person are devoted to love and caring – in the sense of my responsibility for those attached to me, for my family. The wish to do good may be the “honorary president” of the corporation of our personal values, but the values of responsibility and caring for our close ones sit in the CEO’s office.

Family is a system of maximal mutual dependence; we are bound to it both as those who are cared for and as those who care for others, in proportions that change across the stages of life. Beyond the material and emotional benefits of these close circles of dependence, the feelings of attachment and belonging that they engender seep deeply into our sense of meaning. To a great extent, they constitute the emotional core of that sense, and perhaps – on a deep psychological level – even **produce it to begin with**. The “normal” person lives for his close circle, and discovers (consciously) or feels (unconsciously) that the main taste of his life lies in this active belonging: in the responsibility and demands, but also in the vitality and satisfaction that flow from them.

I am not trying to make here a metaphysical claim, nor even a particularly innovative one. I am offering a schematic, generalized description of mental health. Clinical psychology research shows a tight correlation between indices of social isolation and cutting off from primary circles of closeness and indices of severe psychopathology – depression, addiction, suicidality or psychosis. Our connection with other people – especially those who are meant to surround our lives closely – is like a lifeline for the deeper strata of the soul. The soul needs to hang on to someone beyond itself in order to feel that there is a purpose, a sufficiently grounded reason to bear life **for their sake**.

### **A Name in the World**

At a deep and distant level of our consciousness, underneath many layers of repression and distraction, the knowledge that our life is finite smolders. Like a live coal, this awareness can flare up at any moment, threaten all that covers it over, all that we build when we are not thinking about death.

In the face of the terrible threat of nothingness, a fundamental yearning arises to leave a mark upon reality – something of me that will remain

here after I am gone. A person cannot bear the thought that the short span allotted to his life is all that he is. He is compelled to grasp, in some way, at eternity – at collective memory, at history.

In the language of the Bible this mark is called a **“name” (shem)**:

“His remembrance is lost from the earth, and he has no name abroad” (Job 18:17).

Things that will be called by a person’s name and will continue to exist after him constitute an ongoing echo of his memory. Through them his life gain a meaning that goes beyond being a mere episode.

Scripture recognizes this human need to leave one’s name in the world and gives it expression in several narratives and laws. The builders of the tower in Babel say:

“Let us build ourselves a city and a tower whose top is in the heavens, and let us make a name for ourselves, lest we be scattered over all the earth” (Gen. 11:4).

The laws of **yibbum** (levirate marriage) in Deuteronomy describe a brother who marries the widow of his childless brother, “so that the firstborn whom she bears shall stand in the name of his dead brother, so that his name not be erased from Israel” (Deut. 25:6). And at the end of the book of Ruth, Boaz declares that he acquires the property of Elimelech and also takes Ruth the Moabite as a wife “to raise up the name of the dead upon his inheritance, that the name of the dead not be cut off from among his brothers and from the gate of his place” (Ruth 4:5, 10).

In their primary sense, a person’s “name” and “remembrance” are the linguistic trace he leaves in the consciousness of others – which then symbolize his figure and value in the eyes of human society. Some acquire a name through extraordinary deeds that distinguish them from the rest – “They were the mighty men of old, men of name” (Gen. 6:4); “The memory of the righteous is for blessing, and the name of the wicked shall rot” (Prov. 10:7).

At the same time, the verses show that the natural, normative way of leaving a name, of securing one’s remembrance for ever, is through children and inheritance. Those children will continue the chain of generations; they will live and die on the same parcel of land remembered as yours, and will bequeath to their children the accumulated property and heritage of your family. In this way, according to the Torah, a person can lie in his grave in peace, knowing that his name has not been erased and his remembrance has not been lost from the earth – that his temporary existence has had consequences for what happens in the land

in the ever-unfolding present: “A generation goes and a generation comes, but the earth stands forever” (Eccl. 1:4).

This particular picture of inheritance and land is – we must admit – rather ancient and romantic, and does not appear in exactly the same way in modern life. Yet I think that the desire to leave our name in the world still stands at the heart of the meaning our soul finds in life.

Try to imagine: how much of your sense of meaning would remain if you knew that the culture to which you belong would cease to exist the moment your life ended? Or, alternatively, how much would remain if your life were suddenly transported to some isolated corner of the galaxy, or sealed inside a completely closed bubble – and you knew with certainty that no other human being would ever know of your existence and your actions?

Our ability to sustain a sense of meaning in our finite life is bound up with a deep identification with, and active joining to, our cultural-human community. Here, too, meaning leans on the human other.

### **Social Desirability, Value and Identity**

Up to this point, we have spoken about circles of life in which other human beings occupy, *openly and consciously*, an important place in constructing our sense of meaning. Now I want to take one step further inward and suggest that the face of the other has a formative, decisive role even in those domains of existence that feel most inner and personal – the domains in which we shape our values, our identity, our self-concept and our sense of worth.

In social psychology the term “**social desirability**” describes a person’s wish to be accepted by society. We all recognize in ourselves that inner voice that influences and directs our behavior in different social contexts according to what we feel is expected of us, according to what we sense will be well-received by those around us. But we do not always notice how deep the place from which this voice emerges is; to what extent social desirability is finely wired into almost every corner of the personality, to the point that it is hard – perhaps impossible – to distinguish between a desire that comes “from within me” and one that arises from the internal presence of the face of my other.

From the very beginning of life we vitally need the emotional bond and attention of our parents. Attachment theory has presented empirical and biological evidence for this need, which is no less basic than the infant’s need for oxygen, food and sleep. We need a human envelope of touch, warmth and closeness. We cannot develop in a healthy way unless the

face of our caregivers – our primary environment in infancy – is turned toward us, with devotion, concern and even love and delight.

The good face my parents present to me builds the hard core of my sense of self-worth. Just as my parents teach me how to relate to things in the world, they teach me how to relate to myself and what degree of regard I may claim. Parents who love “well enough” confer on the infant the sense that he is worthy of love. As he develops, his psyche internalizes that attitude into its inner voice; he will feel desirable and of value.

By contrast, an infant whose face no one truly sees, for whom no one shows love and concern, will develop a very fragile soul. Confronted with the difficulties of the world and the challenges of life, that soul will lack the most fundamental fuel for the engine of inner life: the sense that it deserves love.

But despite the centrality of this early developmental layer of the attachment need, it is not confined to childhood. We continue to need the face of our others in ever-widening circles as the human world opens up before us in our growing up. Even as an adult, there remains in me a basic psychological need to be recognized, accepted and liked.

Like other beliefs, my sense of my own value requires external validation; I receive that validation from the other’s stance toward me. In the healthy case this need is balanced by the hard core of self-worth that was formed thanks to early parental care. Yet even then, the need shapes vast areas of our behavior. Some portion of our attention, especially when we are among other people, is devoted to that secondary gaze upon ourselves through the eyes of the other. We want our image to be reflected as positive and liked, that people think well of us and recognize our virtues.

As we mature, the basic psychic need for the other’s face also broadens in the way it is realized. For infants, the face in question is the literal, concrete face of the caregiver: physical presence, frequent responsiveness, the emotions expressed in day-to-day interaction. As we grow, we develop capacities for **internalization** that enable us to carry “objects” with us even when they are not physically present. The face we seek to please, whose affirmation we crave, becomes part of our inner world.

The sphere of behavior linked to this desire to please thus expands greatly. As a toddler, there are times when I consciously seek my caregivers’ attention, and other times – when that need is sufficiently satisfied – in which I am absorbed in my own inner world of play and immediate needs. As an adult, these domains intermix. Most of our behavior is planned and managed at a “higher-explanation” level that

brings into play values, attitudes and deliberate judgment. And it appears that social desirability exerts a considerable influence upon those as well.

Behavior whose *explicit, conscious* goal is to win the positive attention of others is relatively rare in adulthood. Most of us believe that a person should lead his life by his *own* values and deep, personal aspirations, and not content himself with pleasing others. But beneath the surface, interpersonal and social dynamics shape our higher-level self-management – our values and our judgment. Even the “private” lines of behavior we choose are selected in the light of how they radiate onto our identity.

Identity rests precisely on the seam between the “I” and the “outside.” One of its legs descends into the most personal and intimate depths of the personality; the other stands as an active player on the social field. Identity is the story I tell myself about who I am. On the face of it, this is an inner story I tell myself alone. Yet at the same time, it is a deeply social story. It has no context, meaning or emotional quality unless it is placed within the cultural and social space in which I live.

For my story to sound coherent and meaningful in my own ears, it must be the kind of story that *could* be understood by my interlocutors, the people thanks to whom my language exists and bears meaning. For me to feel that this identity is positive, I must imagine how it is perceived as positive in the eyes of human circles beyond myself. Both the meaning of the story and its emotional tone are born as a reflection bouncing back toward me from the face of the other. I am not telling myself my story only to myself, but always also with an imagined wider audience in mind.

In short, our primal need to receive a good face from the other becomes refined and extended into the broad categories of “self-worth” and “identity.” By aligning ourselves with values that are valued by the society in which we live, and maintaining a personal-social identity that is appreciated, we carry within us the good face of the other even when solitary, even when doing things “in private.” In this sense, it is impossible to draw a clear border between what I want out of pure, inner, personal will and what has seeped into my will from social values and expectations. My gaze upon myself – the basis for every story that can confer meaning upon my life – is saturated throughout with the gaze of my other.

## **Summary**

On our journey so far we have looked at several circles of life which, from different angles, anchor our sense of meaning. We spoke of morality and the desire to make the world better; of family and the intimate human circle to which I am intensely responsible in everyday life; of the quest for



eternity, the wish to leave a mark and the cultural joining that makes this possible; and finally of the community of discourse, of the broader society, of its accepted values and of the way we shape our identity, values and behaviors with the other's gaze constantly present.

The central claim of this part has been that despite the undeniable differences between these circles, their common denominator – the basic reason they are able to ground our sense of meaning – is that they all rest upon **the face of the human other**.

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## **B. The Heavens**

At some point in history, however, a new consciousness bursts forth. It seeks to break out of these horizontal anchors of meaning and to direct the human gaze upward, to the **heavenly**. A religious-spiritual domain of meaning is born, and it claims first place in the human heart, in opposition to his natural-human circles of belonging.

Already the ancient religions weave narratives whose core is a relation between the human being and some non-human entity. That relation is sometimes modeled by analogy to the absolute relations we know – a totem, for example, may represent the father or mother of the tribe – and sometimes through a story of deliverance, in which the human being owes everything to the god who protects the tribe or the people, feeds them, grants them bounty, protection, fertility and blessing.

In any case, the bottom line of the religious myth is the highlighting of this relation to what is non-human or super-human, and the elevation of that relation above the natural-human ties that characterize non-religious existence, the space of **chol** (the profane).

In the Abrahamic religions this move reaches a peak of clarity. God is both Creator and Sustainer, both Protector and Teacher, both Judge and Compassionate One, and our dependence upon Him is absolute. The relation to God does not end with a sense of dependence and obligation; it develops into a relationship of rich, intense emotional contours – love and cleaving on the one hand, fear and awe on the other. God Himself calls upon the human being to make the religious relation decisive in the texture of his life: “You shall love the Lord your God with all your heart, with all your soul, and with all your might” (Deut. 6:5).

In many religions, withdrawal from the public – **separation from society** – is an essential aspect of the experience considered the core of religious existence: the mystical-spiritual life epitomized by the monk. Of course, the mystical experience is not the lot of the many, and the monastic way

of life is esoteric. Religions also lay out more normative ways of life in which participation in the life of the religious community, rather than seclusion, stands at the center.

Yet even so, there is in religion a central element of standing **alone** before the Creator. We see this in the heart of prayer – the Amidah, in Judaism, is recited quietly by each individual – and in religious norms that call for cheshbon nefesh, self-examination, confession, standing before the good and the bad in one's deeds, including those performed in secrecy.

In any case, the critical point here is that religion **brackets off** the human being from his horizontal ties – not necessarily in practice and external behavior, but essentially. Into the life of the “natural” human being – the social animal who always exists within some social order and organization: tribal, communal, political, cultural – religion introduces, for the first time, a distinct **vertical axis**.

It gives rise to a sphere of relation that is both intimate and absolute, and that is not harnessed to the web of interpersonal bonds that makes up the rest of our obligations. God wants the world, takes interest in the twists and turns of my human life, and asks that I crown Him through my faith and my good deeds. He presents the world with an exalted purpose, a radiant messianic future and a horizon of holiness and mystery.

My life can acquire **eternal meaning** if I bind them to God's love, to God's command, to God's perspective on reality. My self-worth receives from God a profound and unique importance – “For my sake the world was created” – even if I do not feel important or special when measured against the social matrix in which I live.

All of this grants the person a living, powerful connection to a distinct, a-social direction. It can capture his heart and rally his life around it.

This religious relation – the human-God relationship – opens up a **gap** between a person and his bonds to the human other. It allows him to “turn his back” to the other and to build meaning for his life within his private, inner space. At the religious or metaphysical-spiritual level that religion establishes, life receive validation and worth without needing to rest on any other human being. One can feel oneself as existing in one's own right, as having value and meaning in one's own right, as a being who constitutes a world unto himself.

God's gaze on a person's life, and the person's response to that gaze, create an entire atmosphere of meaningfulness that can render unnecessary his dependence on others' gazes. This meaning is accessible to every individual, in any social class:

“Let not the eunuch say, ‘Behold, I am a dry tree.’ For thus says the Lord: To the eunuchs who keep My sabbaths, and choose what I desire, and hold fast to My covenant – I will give them, in My house and within My walls, a place and a name better than sons and daughters; an everlasting name will I give them that shall not be cut off” (Isa. 56:3-5).

Religion’s bracketing off from interpersonal bonds is thus not only a byproduct but part of its content. In offering a vertical life-purpose, it teaches a person to recognize the **contingency** – the finitude, limitation and mortality – of the soul’s horizontal anchors. All life here will eventually end; all that is built here will ultimately decay into dust. Human morality is relative, fashion-dependent and changeable; honor and wealth do not descend with a person to the grave; “Vanity of vanities, all is vanity.”

Therefore, the only true foundations for a life of meaning are those offered by religion: the World to Come, the absolute divine command, eternal reward. Religious faith calls the person to rise above horizontal bonds, to see in them distractions from the essential to the incidental. As part of placing the religious-vertical axis at the center of the value-picture, it **downplays** the worth of society and the other – both as normative ideal and as source of meaning. The face of God replaces the face of the other.

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### **C. Between Heaven and Earth**

The core proposal of this essay concerns the relationship between these two axes: the network of horizontal bonds that ties a person to the human other, and the vertical-religious network that lifts a person toward cleaving to God. Let us expand a bit on the complexity of this relationship and some of the patterns that have been suggested for mediating between the axes – and then I will offer my own.

I described above the “softening” effect the religious tendency can have on horizontal obligations and dependencies. Different configurations of religiosity – across religious cultures, and even across currents and sub-groups within a single religion – differ in their basic stance toward these horizontal bonds, and in the extent to which religious obligation is set up as an alternative and competitor to them.

In the cult of Molech, for example, a person was required to sacrifice his own children – the most radical symbolic gesture of absolute subordination to the god, of canceling the most basic, natural human bonds.

This tendency – to make social norms and interpersonal commitments yield to religious norms – appears in other religions as well, including the

Abrahamic faiths. The kingship of Heaven is conceived as prior, in essence and normatively, to any bond toward any human being. All creatures are equally subject to the One who created them.

On the other hand, at least in the Abrahamic traditions and in Judaism in particular, a large portion of God's commands concern public and social life: ordering interpersonal relations, establishing systems of justice and charity, and forming norms of fairness, fellowship and kindness.

Indeed, the religious experience bears within it a built-in tension between these two axes of reference and obligation. Anyone who has ever felt torn between, say, a religious practice and the norms of his family or friends knows something of this. So does anyone whose wish to pray with inner concentration is disturbed by his worry about how that prayer looks in the eyes of those around him; anyone whose desire to honor the other at times collides with religious values; in general, anyone who wants to align his heart with Heaven yet knows that his heart also longs for the recognition and affection of other human beings.

The basic religious stance will always crown the relation to God as the first and more absolute obligation relative to others. Yet this precedence is not necessarily a central, explicit emphasis in religious life. On the contrary: streams of Jewish thought and practice that focus on actively opposing the axes – that constantly ask “which is more important, between a person and his fellow, or between a person and God?” – actually deviate from the middle path of Judaism. In Judaism there has never been a simple, sharp answer to that question.

An active opposition between vertical commitment to God and horizontal commitments (to the other, to society, to humanity) can lead religion down a dangerous, even destructive, path. What begins as liberation from dependence on the horizontal can slide into detachment from it. Seeing horizontal obligations as “less important” than religious ones can easily become seeing them as **unimportant**.

Yet throughout the Bible – from Adam, Cain and Noah to Abraham, Moses, Isaiah and Amos – God turns to the human being not in order to free him from brotherhood and responsibility, but to confirm and deepen them.

How, then, can we deal with the tension between these axes that cross the heart of the religious person like warp and woof? I will briefly sketch two “keys” that have been proposed within Judaism, and then suggest a third.

## **1. The Horizontal as a Derivative of the Vertical**

The more prevalent key in contemporary Jewish thought, it seems to me, is to view horizontal morality as a **derivative** of vertical religious obligation – that is, of the obligation to Torah and mitzvot. God commands us to do what is upright and good; as a result, we are obligated toward the other.

The horizontal domain is then simply a sub-domain of religious duty. Horizontal obligations are defined through the prism of “mitzvot bein adam le-chavero,” commandments between a person and his fellow, which are part – a special, indeed central part, but still part – of the 613 commandments given at Sinai.

Judaism thus grants a divine imprimatur to the moral intuition that calls us to step out toward the other. In this view the hierarchy between heaven and earth is clear: God is the source of command and authority, and the human other – “my fellow” – is the one toward whom I bear obligation **by virtue of God’s command**.

At the same time, the wide space that Torah and halakhah allocate to interpersonal morality, together with the unique spiritual power of religious commitment, establish a very high importance for the moral-social domain. Foundational texts repeatedly emphasize that tikkun olam – repairing the world through justice and law and charity and compassion – is the very goal toward which God directs His guidance to humanity:

“For I have known him, that he may command his children and his household after him to keep the way of the Lord, to do righteousness and justice” (Gen. 18:19).

“For I am the Lord, who acts with kindness, justice and righteousness in the earth, for in these I delight” (Jer. 9:23).

Hillel the Elder put it in a famous aphorism in the Talmud: “What is hateful to you, do not do to your fellow – this is the whole Torah; the rest is commentary, go and learn” (BT Shabbat 31a).

Religious thinkers will often highlight the advantage of this understanding over a secular humanistic one in which the binding force of moral obligation rests only on human intuition or conscience. The human being is full of weakness of will and shortness of understanding; someone bound only by his own judgment can easily drift, be swept into self-deception, moral laxity, laziness and worse. Natural morality changes and flips constantly; a person has no guarantee that the implementation of his human values really leads the world to a better place.

By contrast, divine guidance is not only more true and accurate than what our limited understanding reaches; it also grants spiritual powers that

strengthen a person's grasp of morality. Religion brings with it an expansive, piercing language, one that embraces the story of all existence and ties it to the concrete, detailed, everyday religious-moral duties placed upon the individual. Religion drives the person through fear of punishment, pulls him with cords of love and mystery, energizes him with exalted visions and softens his heart with images of humility, wonder and gratitude.

Every "horizontal" moral deed channels into itself an enormous energy of cleaving, of striving for holiness and of tikkun olam all at once. In this view, the horizontal obligations **gain** by being harnessed to religious language – the latter serving as a kind of "resonance chamber" for the demand that we dedicate ourselves to doing what is upright and good.

And yet this key to the relationship between the horizontal and the vertical is not free of difficulties. In the soul, the moral drive is **independent**; it does not depend on religious faith or fear of Heaven. There is something that does not sit quite right in trying to "translate" horizontal obligations toward the other into the hierarchical, legal-halakhic religious language.

Do I love my friends or honor my parents because there is a mitzvah in the Torah to do so, or because I feel that this is right? Does God want me to perform acts of kindness with the same inner tone with which I fulfill the mitzvah of tzitzit or the obligation to check for insects in leafy vegetables?

In a broader sense, trying to pass the emotional and psychic energies of the horizontal bond through the lens of religious duty produces a certain dissonance. I do not think this cancels the positive effect that the hierarchical view can have on our commitment, devotion and enthusiasm for moral action toward the other.

But that effect remains confined to the **normative** aspect of the horizontal bond, whereas the full domain of the horizontal in the soul is far wider, as we have seen. This mismatch may be the deep source of the dissonance. The normative field, which includes both the vertical and the moral, rests on a deep psychic root that points outward, beyond the self, that seeks to anchor life in something outside and beyond the narrow circle of self.

By contrast, the horizontal bond as a whole concerns another psychic domain, no less deep, that is intertwined with the most basic feelings of being a self and that is, by nature, mutual and reciprocal. Human relationships – and love, as their crown – are **two-directional** movements

of soul in which I do not only go out toward the other but also bring him within; in which I do not only give but also receive.

This is precisely what allows the horizontal bond to encompass life and psyche so broadly. Whereas religiosity and morality *demand* of the person, relationships interweave harmoniously between the demands the other places upon me and my demands of him; between exertion and expenditure of energy and relaxation and renewal of strength; between giving and receiving.

In any event, a view that reduces the horizontal to a mere normative derivative of religiosity is not sufficient, because the horizontal bond contains much more than mere “obligation.” Its broad place in the soul, as I have tried to show, demands a more substantial treatment than its reduction to “mitzvot bein adam le-chavero.” We therefore turn to another key that tries to embrace the horizontal and vertical wings of the soul together.

## 2. Mystical Unity and Love of All

At the heart of the mystical-religious experience, according to some formulations, stands a sense of **ontological unity**: the sense that all parts of reality are manifestations of one living, all-embracing oneness – “all existence is included in a single point.”

There is a certain vantage point, which requires effort and inner 集中, from which the world appears as a kaleidoscope of sparks spraying out of a single encompassing existence. Everything seems lit from within by one soul of the life of worlds.

The sense of the unity of all comes bound together with a sense of **love for all**. Because I am part of the All, and the All is one, my self-love spreads to everything; or, from the other direction, out of my love for all, everything is revealed as one and as bubbling forth from my own soul.

A religious teaching that places the mystical experience at its center – the aspiration and orientation to it, or at least to the spiritual consequences and principles that flow from it – can offer a very different key for shaping the relationship between vertical and horizontal bonds: the key of **unity**.

From this perspective there is no need to differentiate between two axes. Just as love of God is transformed almost effortlessly into an all-embracing love-of-all, and back again, so this love of all is concretized as love for every living creature, especially every human other.

The mystical experience seems to lift a curtain and expose that we are dealing with different levels of one and the same bond: a bond of burning love and overflowing unity. The movements of soul directed toward the

human others around us – our need and dependence, our pull and desire for contact, for touch and for face – are in the end only a particular, important case of the same spiritual channel that connects our selfhood to the whole of being and to the Source of being (blessed be He).

This mystical-unitive key is profoundly true. For a person who is presently standing in that point of view, there is no tension between vertical and horizontal.

However, the mystical perspective carries within it its own limitation. By nature, it is a “high,” intense, energetic experience, whose transience is built into it. For all but a very few, this perspective is available only in edge-moments; its horizon does not remain open long enough to accompany life continuously.

The everyday experience, even if we strive mightily, remains on the plane the kabbalists call “alma de-piruda,” the world of separation. The intoxication of love-of-all cannot, over time, banish from the heart the entire natural range of our emotions.

In that “normal” experiential space, even if the intellect tells us that all being is a revelation of God’s infinity, our soul continues to feel its various layers as distinct and separate. The bond toward God as Creator and Commander remains experientially distinct from the weave of feelings that tie us to our human others.

Furthermore, the unitive key tends to blur and sometimes erase all distinctions and boundaries in the world-picture. It indeed fuses the vertical longing for God with the horizontal bonds toward the human beings around me. But in the same breath, it includes within that unity all creatures and all forces.

My heart’s stirrings toward the face of the other are mixed with my wonder at the beauty of music and the colors of the rainbow, at the splendor of nature and the glory of wisdom.

In the key I will now propose, I want to give a more specific answer for the horizontal bond **as it stands opposite the vertical**, and to establish these two together as foundational pillars of the life of the soul.

### **3. Tzelem Elohim**

The gate to an existential experience that peacefully fuses the religious-vertical and social-horizontal bonds lies in the consciousness that human beings are an exceptional revelation of God in our world.

The Torah, which fiercely opposes any idolatrous system that seeks an image or figure through which to represent God’s presence – and forbids



the making of “a graven image or any likeness that is in the heavens above, or on the earth below, or in the waters beneath the earth” (Ex. 20:4) – leaves only one thing in creation of which it can be said that it bears the “form” of God:

“And God created the human in His image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them” (Gen. 1:27).

“On the day when God created Adam, in the likeness of God did He make him” (Gen. 5:1).

Much has been written about the revolutionary force of this new idea, which appears in the written Torah with a clarity and explicitness unprecedented in the surrounding cultures of the ancient Near East.

Humanity’s being crowned with the title “tzelem Elohim” has countless implications for the worldview of the Bible and deeply shapes its morality, politics, law, religion and value-system. It is an idea so powerful and provocative – carrying energy almost like that of a nuclear core – that even today, thousands of years after it was first stated, we are still working through its full meaning.

Unlike other readings of this foundational idea, though not in contradiction to them, I want to translate it into a consciousness in which the face of the human other is experienced as a **divine revelation**. We can learn to experience human social encounter as a kind of **touch of the divine** in our lives – and from there, to understand that the web of bonds and relations that enmesh us with others do not stand in opposition to our bond and obligation to God. Rather, they contain within them a manifestation of the Shekhinah and genuine avodat Hashem, service of God.

Let us now stretch this consciousness over the different domains in which the horizontal bond anchors life’s meaning, as described above, and see how it can suture together the horizontal and vertical tendencies within our spirit.

Our moral drive propels us to care for and benefit the humans around us, in widening circles. That drive is not derived from religious longing or fear of God. Yet at a deeper level, the recognition that the face of my other shines with a special divine light colors the natural moral will itself with vibrant religious hues. It renders superfluous the conflictual debate over “which comes first,” religion or morality, bein adam le-chavero versus bein adam la-Makom.

The wish to do good *for someone* and the wish to do God’s will both channel the same current of goodness. The desire to benefit another is, in

this light, a parallel conduit of the desire to bring joy to God, for in both flows that same basic generosity. Thus we can experience the moral will itself as an expression of the soul's fundamental movement beyond itself – a movement that is directed also toward God.

The small kindness of pouring someone a glass of water, the shining of the face in a smile, any large or small good deed we do for another out of simple, sincere goodwill – all of these can, with a small inner shift, be experienced from within as sacred and “religious” acts.

This way of looking can cast a new light over the moral will and all its detailed expressions in life, connecting it to the religious framing-story without displacing it, even by a hair's breadth, from the natural, value-based frame.

This connection strengthens and enriches both realms. The religious narrative draws vitality and emotional power from the horizontal bond; the natural moral narrative is enriched by the breadth and scope of the religious narrative – by its ability to bind heaven and earth, the temporal and the eternal, beginning and end.

In the family circle, life are often an unceasing intensity of contact, responsibility and concern, which can push aside the gentler tendencies of the heart – spiritual, religious and moral alike.

Consciousness of *tzelem Elohim ba-zulat* – the image of God in the other – illuminates life **within** this interpersonal business, even when it is gray, even when the heart is not aglow with love and kindness.

My little daughter, about whom I am alternately angry and delighted at a dizzying pace, is not only a duty and responsibility, and not only an endless love of a father for his child. She also shines for me with the light of God's face. All her sweetness, and all her piercing independence, and her developing intelligence, and the charm of her play – each of these is a shard, a nuance, a hue of our pull toward that human-divine light: the unique, one-time light that appears in *this* child of mine, and the more general light whose source is the Source of all, blessed be He.

Here we have the seed of a kind of Copernican revolution in how we chart **chol** and **kodesh** in religious life. The basic order of natural life within a family unit and within the spaces of a social circle is not a realm of pure profane existence. It is a **theological arena**, the primary stage of avodat Hashem, where I interface with the greatest manifestations of God available to me.

Service of God is not only that “holy” dimension for which I must carve out time and space and mental resources from a pie of efforts mostly devoted

to the family sphere – that simple, encompassing and most concrete reality of life.

Avodat Hashem lies within the very heart of that family and interpersonal existence. Every other human being before whom I stand, and certainly those with whom my life is bound up on a daily basis, is a revelation of God to me. Every interaction with them is a partial form of my touch with God, my opportunity to bring God joy, to love Him, to identify with Him and have compassion upon Him, to respond to Him and to give myself over to Him.

This can transform how we experience the obligations and moral aspects of the horizontal bond, as described above – but just as much, it can transform its **joy and delight**. The joy of togetherness, the longing to be close to people I love, the sweetness of friendship, family and couplehood – all these become embodiments of cleaving to, and delight in, God. When we train our consciousness on the divine revelation in *tzelem Elohim* in human beings, these feelings become the palette with which we paint our love of God.

Even the natural human desire to leave a mark in the consciousness of others is illuminated by this perspective in a new way – one in which the religious-vertical narrative does not serve as prosecutor but as defender. It does not stand against the wish to leave a name forever and try to diminish it by emphasizing its futility, its limitation and the finitude of all human perspectives.

Rather, it magnifies it and supports it with a broader metaphysical picture. Human vantage points are indeed finite, and every human name is eventually forgotten. Yet eternity peeks through all those points of temporality.

The human faces that affirm my existence are deputized faces of the Creator. God does not scorn the small and large deeds by which I have influenced those who lived alongside me and in my time. On the contrary: the most relevant manifestation of God's pleasure in my good deeds and in my efforts to repair and improve the world appears precisely **through the eyes of those I tried to benefit**, those whom I hoped would remember my name for a blessing.

Above we mentioned social desirability as the penetrating presence of the other's viewpoint within my own, even in the deepest levels of judgment and identity-formation. This picture can readily arouse discomfort – a sense of lacking true selfhood, or of desecration, of the draining of the "I" of its dignity and of genuine inner substance.

Personally, this picture of “penetrability” both rings true in my heart and pains it – precisely because I clearly feel, at times, the fingerprints of the other on the shaping of my will, social desirability in its simple sense. I judge harshly the pleasing parts of my personality, the degree to which I am influenced by what others think and want.

The culture we live in sanctifies the individual as an autonomous unit: a being moved only by forces arising from within, unique to his essential, original character. Yet against this, psychological reality teaches a very different lesson: there is far more flow between self and other than we might wish to admit. We are creatures who synchronize ourselves with those around us. Our language, our emotions and even our heart rate and breathing patterns automatically adjust to the person before us.

This does not, of course, negate the importance of standing on one’s own, of critical thinking and inner independence. But these must be situated within a broader picture in which there is also room to accept the **influence and penetrability** of the self.

We then presented the vertical religious axis as a counterweight to the tendency to be nullified before the other – whether the concrete other or the general, collective, more abstract other that appears as cultural, value-laden and normative expectations. God’s presence in the story performs a kind of **“surgery”**: the person is separated from his others and becomes alone, granted a space of “self alone.”

But this picture of religion brings, among other things, an unresolved, dissonant tension between the place of the horizontal bond in the human heart and God’s call to him. When the tension is heightened, a person is pushed to choose sides, to identify with one and estrange himself from the other.

Seeing the other as a special manifestation of God adds one more conceptual layer to this system – and at the same time substantially softens the tension.

On the one hand, my penetrability to the other’s face and my wish to please others receive a **religious meaning**, which makes them at home within the religious story, within the vertical narrative of life. I am still serving God wholeheartedly; all I want is to cleave to Him. And from that very desire, knowing that God created my heart so that it yearn for the many different manifestations of God in the world, my social desirability no longer contradicts my religious authenticity at the principle level.

The self is drawn powerfully both toward the horizontal and toward the vertical, but both pulls are significant expressions of the divine.

On the other hand, my ability to tell the story also from a vertical perspective preserves my “self,” my freedom and my sense of agency. Yes, there are traces of the other’s face within me; yes, even in my inner thoughts and in the identity I choose for myself there is some “someone else” I cannot help but address.

But if I recognize that presence, and can stand before it and interpret what it brings forth as an expression and embodiment of the divinity I desire and love from the deepest point of my selfhood, then that presence no longer threatens me. My penetrability is no longer experienced as annihilating the self but as blending with it.

From another angle, the psychic need for honor and affection from those around me undergoes an important transformation and gains a place of honor within the worldview. Instead of being perceived only as a source of “ulterior motives,” of a foreign will standing against the supposedly more “authentic” desire to bring joy to God, the need for social recognition comes to be seen as part of the way our soul receives its basic feeling of validation from the light of the King’s face – from the divine light that shines through human faces.

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## **D. Conclusion**

In this essay I have discussed two “consciousnesses” – the social and the religious – that serve as systems of existential meaning, as answers to the question of the taste and purpose of life.

The religious consciousness, or narrative, is such **explicitly**. By contrast, in the first part of the essay I tried to show that the “natural” way of filling life with a sense of meaning almost always passes through the face of the human other.

I illustrated how the goals that people explicitly or implicitly set as the foundations of their life – to live for my children, to live for my close circle, to live in order to make the world a better place (for the people who inhabit it), to live in order to influence and be remembered – all of these “work” because they rest life upon the human other, because other human consciousnesses appear in our soul as bearers of authoritative affirmation of our being, as conferring value upon our life.

In the second part I elaborated on the religious system of meaning and presented it as an alternative to the social-interpersonal system. Indeed, the common conception of religion calls upon us to rise above human-social anchors of meaning, to see their contingency, limitation and mortality. Religion seeks to elevate our image of God by means of a ladder

that, in the process, tramples the value of society as a source of affirmation, of ideals and of existential meaning.

In the final part I sought to propose another way – a way that does not give up the image of God as infinite, nor the “religious” path of distinct holiness and of Torah and mitzvot, but places the divine revelation present in my human others – and especially in those others I live with daily – as a central **gateway to God**.

Although the social and religious consciousnesses can appear foreign, even constricting, to one another, we can sketch a worldview that highlights their inner harmony.

According to that picture, founded on faith in *tzelem Elohim* in every person, we can experience interpersonal bonds as forms of revelation and cleaving, and the web of demands and obligations they place upon us as distilled expressions of avodat Hashem.

## Key terminology choices - ChatGPT 5.1

- **God** – I'll write "God" in the main text, but sometimes keep **"Elohim (א-להים)"** in parentheses where the Hebrew nuance matters.
- **צלם א-להים** – will appear as **"tzelem Elohim (the image of God)"** on first mention, then mainly *tzelem Elohim* or *image of God* depending on flow.
- **הזולת** – translated as **"the other"** (sometimes "my fellow human being / my fellow" where it reads better), and occasionally **"ha-zulat (the Other)"** when it's a strong conceptual term.
- **ציר אופקי / ציר אנכי** – **"horizontal axis" / "vertical axis"** or **"horizontal / vertical plane of meaning"**.
- **בין אדם לחברו / בין אדם למקום** – once or twice explicitly as **"bein adam le-chavero (between one person and another)"**, **"bein adam la-Makom (between a person and God)"**; otherwise just "interpersonal commandments / commandments toward God".
- **עולם הבא** – **"the World to Come (olam ha-ba)"**.
- **רצייה חברתית** – **"social desirability (retziya chevratit)"**.
- **קודש / חול** – **"the holy" / "the profane"**, sometimes as **"kodesh / chol"** when it's structurally important.
- Biblical quotations – I'll **quote the Hebrew** briefly and then give a **fresh English rendering**, not a standard Bible translation, and keep them relatively short.